

BOOKS ▼

BLOOD SPORTS

Keshava Guha's *The Tiger's Share* is a tragicomic take on sibling rivalry and other family dynamics

THE TIGER'S SHARE
By KESHAVA GUHA
HACHETTE INDIA
₹699; 256 pages

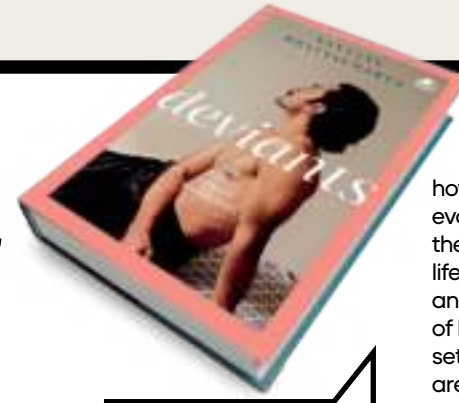
THIS CLEVER, FAST-PACED NOVEL FOCUSES ON A PASSION hotter than sex: the territorial frenzy of a brother challenging his sister's claim to family property. Tara Saxena, the narrator, is a successful lawyer with a cool wit and a knack for snarky-taut summations. Her dim-bunny younger brother Rohit is the classic ne'er-do-well. He's soaked up parental funds while pursuing a foreign degree, then remained in the US still chasing dreams. But when their father retires, Rohit rushes back to India, convinced that his conniving sister will surely snatch the tiger's share of the inheritance all to herself.

Why not "lion's share" you may ask? Because tigers are solitary predators, who typically do not share their spoils. There are a number of tigers in this tale, starting with Tara. Rohit's buddy, the thuggish Kunal Chawla is another selfish tiger, the adoptive son of mega-rich parents. Opposing him is the biological heir to the fortune, Lila, an international financier with a seemingly perfect marriage and young son. When their father dies, Kunal swings into usurper mode and locks his furious sister out of the family "farm house". That's when Lila reaches out to Tara, invoking their youthful friendship to secure legal advice in order to move against the brother.

The sizzling tandoor of New Delhi's summer drives the plot via the sheer scale of its dysfunction. In the midst of this churning urban chaos, the elder Saxena is presented as a model of reason and higher truth. Tara calls him Baba, meaning "father", but the name foreshadows his role as something other than just a beloved parent. We are told that he bootstrapped his way to wealth from origins so humble that he didn't describe them to his family. But when he takes on global climate change as a personal challenge, the link with plausibility snaps altogether.

Which is a shame. Guha's great achievement is to narrate an otherwise dismal story through the perspectives of Tara and, to a lesser extent, Lila. They are both such sterling examples of Indian Alpha Womanhood that when attacked with the rusty old weapons of traditional gender injustice, they fight back like true tigresses. I believe the author owed them a better share of the ending! ■

—Manjula Padmanabhan



BOOKS ▼

Subcontinental Drift

Santanu Bhattacharya's *Deviants* chronicles being queer, across generations

DEVIANTS: THE QUEER FAMILY CHRONICLES
By Santanu Bhattacharya
TRANQUEBAR
₹799; 304 pages

Queer narratives from South Asia are hard to come by. In the few that exist, *Deviants* stands out as an ambitious debut novel that combines three stories of queer love from a single family, delving into the complexities of love, identity, as well as familial and societal norms surrounding same-sex relationships in India.

The author attempts a broad sweep and succeeds valiantly most of the time. The stories—especially those of queer men Mambro and Sukumar, who came before the protagonist Vivaan—are engaging, heartbreakingly lonely yet resilient.

The novel's exploration of queer identity in a heteronormative society is hard-hitting, particularly through the poignant stories of older gay men and their ongoing struggles. The novel reminds us of the challenges of acceptance, self-hatred, and dissonance that queer South Asians face globally today.

While the multiple stories are enriching, they don't always flow together seamlessly. The prose, however, is lyrical and evocative, and captures the contradictions of queer life in India with all its ebbs and flows. The descriptions of Kolkata and the story set in a bygone era of India are particularly vivid and immersive, transporting you to another time.

Deviants is a welcome voice, though one finishes it wishing it had been more engaging. Nevertheless, for a debut novel, it's both bold and determined to tell its truth, bringing a queer perspective with empathy and insight to its readers. Despite shortcomings, it marks Bhattacharya as a writer to watch. ■

—C. Mehra